NO. 138 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

TUESDAY 20 OCTOBER 2026



AMERICAN ENERGY PRICES ROSE 20.4% IN A YEAR (P14)

THE WORLD

Paris curfews République after 550,000 march; Macron flies to Kuwait to ask for diesel

Twelve Desks · One World

THE ATELIER

Six guitars, one difference, and thirty-one blindfolded players who could not hear it

THE RABBIT HOLE

The handmade-bicycle show opens in Osaka on Friday, its first time in Asia

Source: an AFP photograph published by Al Jazeera, 19 October 2026, opened and examined by this desk before captioning — French forensic police and a fire officer at a gutted building behind barriers. The fire service on the officer's vest is the Rhône's, so this is not the Limoges town hall named on p3. Cropped; no other alteration.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 138

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FROM THE DESK

"Everything is connected to everything else."

Barry Commoner, *The Closing Circle*, 1971 — the first of his four laws of ecology[1]

Commoner meant it about ecosystems, and complained for the rest of his life that it was quoted as a sentiment. It is not a sentiment today. One number on p14 — energy up a fifth in a year — is simultaneously an American rate decision, a French curfew and a wage guideline in Singapore.

THE STRIP · AT MONDAY'S CLOSE

US 2-year[2]	4.77%	▲ 3bp
US 10-year[2]	5.15%	▲ 6bp
VWRA	$191.58	▼ 0.05%
Global agg	$5.76	▼ 0.35%
DXY	102.00	▲ 0.16%
USD/SGD	1.2787	▼ 0.07%
Brent	~$109	▼ 0.1%
Gold	$4,140.52	▼ 0.60%
Bitcoin	~$82,000	▲ 1.1%

The Straits Times Index closed **5,412.00**, down 0.07 per cent (**p14**). **Brent and bitcoin are rounded because two services disagreed on contract and snapshot time.** Not advice.[2]

FROM THE ARCHIVE · TUESDAY

No. 136 reported UKMTO could not count the attacks. No. 137 printed the count it then published. This week the centre says in its own words that it is struggling to report the true number — so the figure is a floor (p4).

No. 137 dated the Graham Act waiver to 17 October and gave it a 2031 sunset. The White House text says the 16th, and gives it no sunset at all. Both are corrected today (p4).

No. 130 took this desk inside locksport. The Rabbit Hole returns to the workshop from the other end today — the people who make the thing rather than open it (p15).

No. 136 held September's export figure because the agency refused the request. Its own PDF gave it up this week: **68.4 per cent**, and a footnote that will not print the biggest contributor's growth rate (p5).

No. 134 printed a tanker nobody would claim. She was the Singapore-flagged GFS Pride, and she is the second hull lost since February (p4).

SOURCES 1 Barry Commoner states the four laws of ecology in *The Closing Circle: Nature, Man and Technology* (Knopf, 1971); the first is given here as he numbers it. **The remark about his later irritation is widely reported of him and is given as characterisation, not as a quotation.** 2 Levels at Monday 19 October's close, each sourced on **p14**, with changes against 16 October; **Treasury yields read row by row from the US Treasury's own daily par yield curve file. Reuters, CNBC, MarketWatch, the FT and the Singapore exchange's own interface all refused this desk; nothing above was printed that could not be read at a stamped quote.**

THE WORLD · FRANCE

Paris curfews Place de la République after 550,000 marched and 2,400 were arrested

Macron refused Laurent Nuñez's offer to resign on Monday. Almost 1,000 police were hurt on Saturday, seven seriously, and the 140-year-old Limoges town hall was largely destroyed.

Paris imposed a curfew on **Place de la République** and the streets around **Les Halles** from **eleven at night on Monday 19 October**, and banned all gatherings in the city from eight. They followed a nationwide day of action on **Saturday 17 October** that the interior ministry counted at **550,000** marchers, **110,000** of them in Paris; organisers said 800,000. Around **2,400** people were arrested.[1]

What began on **21 September** as a protest about school conditions in one Paris borough has fused with fuel and food prices and a revived *gilets jaunes* strand. The fiscal trigger is **Sébastien Lecornu**'s 2027 budget, taking the deficit from **5.4 to 5.0 per cent** of output. Almost **1,000** police were injured out of **60,000** deployed.[2]

Emmanuel Macron addressed the country on Sunday. **« Ceux qui ont détruit doivent payer. »** Those who destroyed must pay; those **« qui ont cherché à faire tomber la République »** will answer for it. He said the country felt **"anger and shame"** and blamed **"agitators from ultra-left fringe groups"**. The presidential election is six months away. On Monday he **refused Nuñez's resignation**, the Élysée saying he wanted the chain of command intact.[3]

He spent Monday in Kuwait asking for diesel, which is the thing his streets are angry about the price of.

Then he left. Macron began a four-country Gulf tour on **19 October** — Kuwait, the Emirates, Bahrain, Qatar — to secure oil and diesel and discuss what the Élysée called **"alternative and bypass routes"**. The **G7, under French chairmanship, agreed in early October to release 100 million barrels**. American energy prices rose **20.4 per cent** in the year to September (p14). This is that shock, arriving as politics.[4]

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Reads it through the far right. **Peter McPhee** of Melbourne calls the violence a **"Christmas present"** for Le Pen's National Rally: *"It is easy for Le Pen to make the link between the violent attacks on buildings and shops with African migrants."*[5]

BEIJING — GLOBAL TIMES

Publishes no commentary at all. Its only item on France's crisis is a consular advisory citing CCTV News, telling Chinese nationals to **"remain alert to potential risks"**. The restraint is the editorial choice.[6]

~3,000

PEOPLE IN FRANCE'S ENTIRE FAR-LEFT MOVEMENT, AS SIZED BY FRENCH INTELLIGENCE — AGAINST 550,000 MARCHERS[7]

THE SCEPTIC · AN ORDINARY RIOT AND A POLICING SCANDAL

Sebastian Roché of Sciences Po Grenoble declines the insurrection frame: on damage this is **"probably close to the first two weekends of December 2018"**, the *gilets jaunes* peak. What is unprecedented runs the other way: **"We have a toll that has not been seen in the past 40 years"** in protesters maimed by police, and **"There is no other country in Europe where the police maim protesters as much."** Six have lost hands or eyes in three weeks. **The test is spread, and it resolves this week.**[7]

SOURCES 1 France 24, 18 October 2026, and Al Jazeera, 19 October, both read at source, for the ministry's 550,000 and 110,000, the organisers' 800,000, and every curfew and city. 2 An American wire service's files of 18 and 19 October, read at licensed republishers, for the arrests, the injured police, the 60,000 deployed, the origin and the budget figures. 3 **The Élysée's own text of the 18 October address, read at source**, for both French passages; "anger and shame" and the "agitators" line are France 24's rendering, and **only the spoken version is authoritative**. 4 TRT World, 19 October, read at source, for the tour, the quoted phrase and the G7 release; the energy figure is the Bureau of Labor Statistics' own September release (p14). 5 Al Jazeera, 19 October 2026, read at source. 6 Global Times, 19 October 2026, read at source; it attributes the advisory to CCTV News. 7 An American wire service's 19 October file, read at a licensed republisher, for Roché's three quoted judgements, the six maimings and the intelligence estimate. 8 Al Jazeera, 17 October 2026, read at source, for Alemanno's line and the Belgian, Italian and Portuguese figures. **No count of Thursday's and Saturday's actions existed at press time; the test above is printed as a test, not a prediction.**

HORMUZ · THE COUNT

UKMTO admits an undercount as Kpler puts Hormuz oil at 68% of pre-war

UKMTO logged 254 transits in the week to 16 October against a pre-war norm near 135 a day. War-risk cover has gone from 0.25 per cent of hull value to as much as 10.

The body that counts attacks in the Gulf has published a sentence more useful than any of its numbers. **UKMTO** now states plainly that its own tally understates what is happening, because most targeted vessels have stopped reporting to it at all. Its week to **16 October** logs **at least twelve ships attacked** and **254 transits** — about thirty-six a day against a pre-war norm near **135**. No. 137 printed the centre's **23 attacks this month**; the centre now says that kind of figure is a floor, not a count.[1]

The volume number survives the uncertainty better. **Kpler** put crude through the strait at **11.6 million barrels a day** in the seven days to **13 October**, about **68 per cent** of the **17.1 million** pre-war baseline. A third of the chokepoint is gone and two-thirds still moves — the honest middle between Tehran's *closed* and **Admiral Brad Cooper**'s **"The Strait of Hormuz is controlled by the United States and our regional partners, not Iran."**[2]

The price of passage is where the war is legible. Additional war-risk premium, as a share of hull value, ran about **0.25 per cent** before the war, **2** in June, **7.5 to 10** in late July and **6 to 10** in early October — up to roughly **twenty million dollars** for one supertanker voyage into the Gulf. **Neil Roberts** of the Lloyd's Market Association says cover remains **"available for a price"**. The IMO counts **106 incidents and 24 seafarer deaths** since 28 February. **Araghchi's seven-day offer stands, unanswered.**[3]

SETTING THE RECORD STRAIGHT · THE GRAHAM ACT WAIVER

Two corrections, both read at the White House's own text. No. 137 dated the executive order **17 October**; it is dated **16 October 2026**. No. 137 said the Act sunsets in **2031**; the order carries **no sunset**. Section **4(d)** runs the waivers **"until such time as the President or the Secretary of State"** determines otherwise — indefinite, revocable only by the discretion that granted it. The Senate had passed the bill **86–11**. **Thom Tillis**: **"Beyond irresponsible."** No counter-legislation has been filed.[4]

IN BRIEF

Japan's H3 put a Mars-moon sampler on course at twenty to four this morning. Flight No. 10 left Tanegashima at **04:41:03** Japan time and separated **MMX an hour and eleven minutes** later into a Mars transfer orbit. It reaches Mars in **2027**, lands twice on Phobos, leaves in **2030** and returns **ten grams** of it in **2031**. The vehicle's success rate went from **78 to 80 per cent**.[5]

China grew 4.5 per cent in the third quarter against 4.3 in the second, on an export-only expansion: goods trade **+18.8 per cent**, retail sales **+1.1**. It is what lifted Asian risk appetite on Monday (p14).[6]

Ukraine flew its largest strike of the war at St Petersburg on the night of 17–18 October; Russia said it downed about **1,015** drones. Fires at the oil terminal and the Ruchyi depot; **20,000** lost power. Zelenskyy counted **76 Russian attacks on energy targets** in a week.[7]

THE CHATTER · A SINGAPORE HULL ON THE BOTTOM

The ship that sank was the **GFS Pride**, a **Singapore-flagged** feeder of 2,824 TEU built in 2008. All **21 crew** got off. **Singapore's MPA called the strike unlawful.** CENTCOM says a projectile, not a mine, and that she went down under tow — the second vessel lost since 28 February.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO NAVIES, ONE SEA, NO SHARED NUMBER

Washington says it has cleared the mines and moved **400 ships and 100 million barrels** in a week; Tehran says the strait is unsafe for anyone not coordinating with its own authority. Both claims survive because the instrument has failed: the centre that publishes the count says it cannot make one. **A reported JMIC finding of "no substantiation" for the mine claims could not be read at source.**[2]

SOURCES 1 Al Jazeera, 17 October 2026, read at source, for UKMTO's own admission that its tally understates the attacks, the twelve-ship week and both transit legs; the pre-war daily norm is Windward's, in the same reporting. **ukmto.org itself returned 403 to this desk, so the centre's figures are read at one remove, as in No. 137.** 2 Al Jazeera, 17 October, read at source, for Kpler's flow figures and baseline and Admiral Cooper's quoted claim and counts. **The JMIC line reached this desk only through search aggregation and is flagged as unconfirmed.** 3 Insurance Business, 14 October 2026, read at source, for the whole premium series, its named brokers, the Lloyd's Market Association quotation, the IMO's counts and the GFS Pride's tonnage, build year, crew and loss; Singapore's Maritime and Port Authority release of 14 October for the unlawfulness finding. 4 **The White House's own presidential-actions text, read at source**, for the 16 October date, section 4(d) verbatim and the absence of any sunset; an American wire service's 17 October file, read at a public-broadcast republisher, for the 86–11 vote, the quoted remark and the absence of a counter. 5 A Kagoshima broadcaster's report and a Japanese business daily's file, both 20 October 2026 and both read at source, for the lift-off time to the second, the separation interval, the transfer orbit, the mission dates, the ten-gram target and the success-rate change. 6 Xinhua's report of the National Bureau of Statistics release, 19 October 2026, read at source. **A widely-repeated fixed-asset-investment figure appears nowhere in the release this desk read and is not printed.** 7 An American network's file of 18 October 2026, read at source, for the drone counts, the named sites and Zelenskyy's tally.

SINGAPORE · THE WAGE GUIDELINES

Singapore's National Wages Council recommends 6 to 8% for workers under S$2,800

The Government accepted the guidelines on Monday 19 October. NTUC calls it the highest range since 2021; Mothership reports that barely a quarter of employers met last year's.

The Government accepted the **National Wages Council**'s guidelines for **2026/2027** on **Monday 19 October**, recommending a built-in increase of **6 to 8 per cent** for workers earning up to **S$2,800** a month — the twentieth percentile of full-time citizens. Last cycle was **5.5 to 7.5 per cent** at **S$2,700**: the range is up half a point at both ends and the floors by roughly a third.[1]

The real change is a fourth category. For the first time the Council has written a recommendation for employers that **did not perform well and are loss-making**: at least **S$120**. Chairman **Hsieh Fu Hua**: **"we need to provide greater flexibility, and that's why this new fourth category of employers is an important change."** The employers' federation, which asked for it, framed the year through a **"K-shaped economy"**. The economy grew **6.0 per cent** over three quarters.[2]

Which is where the guidelines meet p3. The pressure that put **550,000** people on French streets on Saturday arrives here as a percentage in an annex, and the instrument is advisory: only the Progressive Wage Model and the Local Qualifying Salary are enforceable. **NTUC president K. Thanaletchimi**: **"Trust is something that we cannot take for granted."**[3]

Four days earlier the same ministry showed what teeth look like, charging **seven employers and an administrative assistant** under the Employment of Foreign Manpower Act for declaring CPF contributions for **local employees who did not work for the companies**.[4]

THE HAZE, AND THE EXPORT PRINT

At 05:00 this morning the west was Singapore's worst region, at **122** with PM2.5 at **105** — the only one still Unhealthy. The north, which No. 137 printed at **93**, is now **88** and the cleanest. Central read **225** on 16 October: a hundred-point island-wide fall in four days, and an incomplete one.[5]

NEA issued three more notices on 19 October, over Kalimantan fires, taking the total to **ten companies**; the Singapore Environment Council put **Asia Pulp and Paper's** green label under temporary restriction.[6]

September's non-oil domestic exports rose 68.4 per cent, electronics up **107.6**. **Read the sceptic first.**[7]

+68.4%

SEPTEMBER NON-OIL DOMESTIC EXPORTS — RESTING SUBSTANTIALLY ON ONE S$3.7BN SHIPPING ITEM[7]

THE CHATTER · THE FORUM READ THE VERB, NOT THE NUMBER

HardwareZone's thread fixes on the wording, not the tiers. **"Wayang only. Talk is free." "What is urge?"** — another poster offering *Encourage? Monitor?* ***The board is self-selecting and sarcastic, and is reported as such.***[8]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO NUMBERS THE AGENCIES HALF-PUBLISHED

The first: Mothership reports that ***"slightly more than a quarter of employers met last year's recommendations"****, against above seventy per cent when the guidelines covered fewer workers.* ***It appears in no other account this desk read, including the ministry's own release, and is printed single-sourced.*** *If it holds, a 6-to-8 recommendation is a press release. The record rests partly on a number its author will not print.*[7][8]

SOURCES 1 ***The Ministry of Manpower's own press release of 19 October 2026, read at source****, for the acceptance, the period and the macro figures; a Singapore news site of the same day for the tier table; two union sites and a trade title for the 2025/26 range, threshold and floors, from which the deltas are this desk's arithmetic.* ***The ministry's own annex PDF returned 502.*** *2 The same Singapore news site, read at source, for the chairman's quoted remark and the employers' federation president's "K-shaped" framing; the ministry's release for the growth, productivity and unit-labour-cost figures. 3* ***NTUC's own account, read at source****, for the quoted line and the percentile calibration. 4* ***The Ministry of Manpower's own release of 16 October 2026, read at source****, for the charges, the statute and the penalties. 5* ***Singapore's own real-time air-quality interface, read directly at two endpoints****, for the index and PM2.5 by region at 05:00 on 20 October 2026; a Malaysian daily carrying Bernama for the 16 October readings.* ***The agency's own pages again rendered nothing machine-readable.*** *6 A Singapore news site's reports of 19 October 2026, read at source, for the Kalimantan fires, the running total and the green-label restriction. 7* ***EnterpriseSG's own release MR No. 046/26 of 16 October 2026, downloaded as a PDF and text-extracted****, for every export figure and the quoted ships-and-boats attribution. 8 A Singapore hardware forum thread of 19 October, read at source, quoted under the handles posted.*

THE ATELIER · ACOUSTIC GUITARS

Kostal charges $18,000 for a Brazilian back and $550 for an Adirondack top

A 2018 paper in the Journal of the Acoustical Society of America built six guitars identical but for the back wood. Thirty-one players in welder's goggles could not tell them apart.

Start with what is not in dispute. **Trevor Gore**, the Australian luthier who co-wrote the standard design textbook, states it plainly: a responsive guitar has **"high average admittance"**, so string energy is **"easily admitted to the soundboard"** rather than reflected back. The top is the radiator. That is the whole case for a solid top, and it is physical.[1]

Now the part the trade would rather you skipped. **Carcagno, Bucknall, Woodhouse, Fritz and Plack** built **six steel-strings to one design, varying only the back and sides** — Brazilian and Indian rosewood, mahogany, maple, sapele, walnut. Thirty-one did a blinded test in dim light wearing **welder's goggles**. The finding: **"guitarists could not easily distinguish the guitars by their sound or feel"**. Discrimination was **"subtle or rare"**.[2]

Hold that against a price list. **Jason Kostal** charges about **US$18,000** to change the back to Brazilian rosewood and about **US$550** to change the top to Adirondack. **Collings** productised the audible variable instead: its **Q Spruce** is graded by **"its damping coefficient… the 'Q factor'"**, measured by striking a billet with a steel ball. The expensive upgrade is the inaudible one.[3]

WHAT EACH STEP BUYS, IN SINGAPORE DOLLARS

Entry of quality: Furch Pioneer S$1,499; Yamaha LL36 ARE, made in Japan, S$4,999. The sweet spot: Martin HD-28 Standard S$5,325. The grail: Greenfield from US$19,500, booking 2030; Somogyi US$60,000, two days' voicing each. Yamaha's Singapore price is inclusive of 9% GST; a guitar imported directly attracts no duty but 9% GST on the landed value, so an S$ price already has the tax inside it. Traugott is closed to orders; Greenfield is booking four years out. Above about US$10,000 the queue is the product.[4]

THE CHATTER · EIGHTY PER CENT HUMIDITY, SOLVED BY OWNERS

On Delcamp, Singapore owners have solved this themselves. **quixilver** runs the air-conditioner until his case reads **55 to 60 per cent** against a room at 75 to 80, and has done so **"for the last 8-9 years in Singapore"**. The warning is **joachim33**'s, quoting a maker's note: a two-way pack **"is not intended for dehumidification in high humidity environments"**. The tropical failure is bridge glue creeping, not a crack.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE THE LOGO TAX LIVES

Bourgeois is an Eastman company. Dana Bourgeois' own 2019 letter: **"I have simply traded my former partners for Eastman."** Touchstone tops are voiced in **Lewiston, Maine**, then **"sent to Eastman's workshop in Bazhou, China"**. One dealer, one day: Touchstone dreadnought **$3,299**; the Maine-built Heritage Vintage **$6,749**. Martin's D-28 Authentic 1937 is **$8,699.99** and **a thousand more aged** — simulated wear on an instrument whose value turns on original finish.[6]

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Mosquito nets & bed canopies — the one tropical object with a published standard behind it.

Irons & steam generators — boiler pressure in bar, and a badge tax scaling with nothing.

Thermal lunch jars — the wide-mouth flask, and the gasket that decides its life.

SOURCES 1 Trevor Gore's own design and innovation pages, read at source, for the admittance quotation and the monopole-mobility measure. 2 **Carcagno, Bucknall, Woodhouse, Fritz and Plack, "Effect of back wood choice on the perceived quality of steel-string acoustic guitars", Journal of the Acoustical Society of America 144(6), 3533–3547 (2018)**, read at a university research repository, for the six-guitar design, the 52 raters, the 31 blinded discriminators, the goggles and both quoted findings; an acoustics reference site associated with a co-author, read at source, for the "subtle or rare" and sustainable-materials quotations. 3 A luthier's published option list for the Brazilian and Adirondack upcharges; Collings' own Q Spruce page, read at source, for the quoted damping-coefficient grading and the impulse method; Gore's innovation page for the tonewood-research quotation. 4 Swee Lee, Luther Music and Yamaha Singapore's own storefronts, read at source, for every Singapore price and the GST-inclusive statement; makers' and dealers' own pages for the Greenfield, Somogyi and Traugott figures and queue positions. **The duty-and-GST position comes from Singapore's own customs guidance plus secondary summaries that disagreed on the rate; a high-value import should be checked with a broker.** 5 Two Delcamp threads of 2017 and 2022, read at source and quoted under the handles posted. **The humidity-pack note is quoted as a forum member reported it; the maker's own page returned 404 to this desk and the note is therefore single-sourced. The Acoustic Guitar Forum, UMGF, The Gear Page, Reverb and Reddit all refused this desk, so none of the usual communities appears above.** 6 A bluegrass trade title of 11 October 2019, read at source, reproducing Dana Bourgeois' letter verbatim; an American dealer's Touchstone description for the Bazhou sentence and its listings for both prices; Martin's own store for the Authentic and Aged prices.

TECHNOLOGY · CHINA'S EXPORT CONTROLS

Beijing made dredger and drone export controls law; the AI list stays a draft

MOFCOM's 16 October announcement proposed 40 technologies, 23 of them AI, and takes comment until 15 November. Monday's batch is effective 18 November.

China's commerce ministry issued two further export-control announcements on **Monday 19 October**, covering **tunnel boring machines** and an adjusted set of **dredger-related items**, both effective **18 November 2026**. Xinhua gave the ministry only in indirect speech: the items **"can be applied for both military and civilian purposes"**. Bloomberg adds new drone types and parts, and dredger components including mud pumps and cutterheads.[1]

Three days earlier the same ministry had published the list everybody was watching — and published it as a draft. Announcement No. 48, issued with the science ministry on **16 October**, proposes **40 technologies**, **23** of them in artificial intelligence, and takes comment until **15 November**. The thresholds are explicit: **10^{26} FLOPs** of training compute, **or** two trillion parameters, **or** a top-ten placing in public assessments.[2]

On the open-source question this desk owes the reader a sharper account than No. 137 printed. That issue reported the carve-out as a permission Beijing could withdraw, attributing it to a named Hacker News reader who had installed Chinese office software to read the original. **No document or analyst this desk read this week uses revocation language**, and a dedicated search for it returned nothing. What the draft does is stranger: releasing model technology as open source **"can constitute a form of technology export"**. Restricted-category technology **needs a licence to be published**, with simplified procedures available, and the exemption that exists is narrow and backward-looking — technology **already lawfully public** is outside scope. It grandfathers what is already out.[3]

Taipei is moving the other way, and this clears a thread held since No. 136. Economy minister **Kung Ming-hsin** told Bloomberg on **12 October** that Taiwan will add **AI servers and leading-edge semiconductors** to its controlled-items list, aligning part of that list with Washington's, in his own framing, under this year's reciprocal trade agreement. Shipping restricted AI hardware to China then becomes a crime under the Foreign Trade Act. **He gave no date, so the date is still held.**[4]

18 Nov

WHEN THE DREDGER AND BORING-MACHINE CONTROLS BITE. THE AI CATALOGUE IS STILL TAKING COMMENTS[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT API ACCESS IS NOT

The ministry is explicit that restricting core model technology **"does not mean restricting AI services to overseas customers"**: an API, a website, an app or a SaaS seat is not an export. Deploying a restricted model on overseas servers is — even for cloud inference — though a Chinese firm running its own overseas compute may qualify for automatic licensing. Firms self-assess, and the ministry calls the facilitated path **"file and go"**.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WAITING FOR GODOT

Graham Webster of Stanford, writing in August, argued that the long-expected Beijing crackdown on open weights rested on flawed assumptions and compared the wait to **Godot**: where Chinese labs held models back it was commercial, not political. **His piece predates Announcement No. 48 by two months — it is the prior that No. 48 tests, not a reply to it. Wendy Cutler** of the Asia Society says the **"fragility of our trade truce cannot be overstated"**; **Leonhard Xu** of Sinolytics notes controls are usually not outright bans. **No American response had been published when this page closed.**[5]

SOURCES 1 **Xinhua's English service, 19 October 2026, read at source**, for both announcements, the product classes, the 18 November date and the quoted formulation; Bloomberg of the same day for the drones and dredger components, **read in headline and lede only, the body being paywalled. A secondary analysis numbering the batch 49 to 52 could not be read and is not printed.** 2 A policy analyst's reading of the MOFCOM text of 16 October 2026 and a trade-regulation newsletter of 19 October, both read at source, for Announcement No. 48, its ministries, the forty technologies, the twenty-three AI entries, the deadline, all three thresholds, the API distinction and the registration duty. 3 The same analyst reading, plus a technology title of 19 October 2026, read at source, for the open-source treatment: the quoted "form of technology export", the prohibited and restricted treatments, the simplified and automatic procedures and the already-public exemption. **Neither uses the word revocable. No. 137's formulation rested on a single reader's account of the original document, was attributed in print to that reader, and is clarified here rather than repeated.** 4 Bloomberg's interview of 12 October, published 16 October, **read at a licensed syndication because Bloomberg itself is paywalled to this desk**, for the minister's alignment statement, which No. 137 printed verbatim and which is paraphrased here, the two categories and the criminal consequence. **The implementation date remains unpublished and is still held, as in No. 136.** 5 A technology-policy publication of 17 August 2026 and a Gulf English daily of 16 October, both read at source, for Webster's argument and both analysts' remarks. **A dedicated search for a Washington response dated 19 or 20 October returned nothing.**

THE HOME LAB · BEAM 1.0

Reflection's 501-billion-parameter Beam runs at 29 tokens a second on one Mac Studio

The Apache-2.0 weights landed on 16 October. The smallest community quantisation is 103 gigabytes, which puts a 32GB RTX 5090 out of the conversation entirely.

Reflection AI published the weights for **Beam 1.0** on **16 October** under **Apache 2.0**: **501.3 billion parameters, 23.4 billion active**, a sparse mixture of experts with **256 experts** across 52 layers, a **one-million-token** context, trained on **23.8 trillion tokens** in under four weeks on **6,144** GB300 accelerators. Tooling caught up within a day: a llama.cpp pull request adding Beam was opened and merged on the **16th**.[1]

The number that matters for this desk was measured on **18 October**, on one machine. A streaming repack keeps the routed experts in Reflection's own four-bit codes on disk and requantises the trunk to eight-bit: **290.8 gigabytes on disk**, run on a single **256GB Mac Studio M5 Ultra** with the wired limit raised, experts streaming from the internal SSD. Peak footprint **236.8GB**. Over a 16,445-token prompt and 1,024 generated tokens across two seeds: **prefill about 1,063 tokens a second, decode 29.06 to 29.49**, first token at **15.9 seconds**. An optional draft lane lifts decode to **33.26**, and the author ships it off by default because it is lossy.[2]

For the card in the other machine the news is blunt. The community GGUF ladder starts at **103GB** and runs to a terabyte; the useful rungs for 256GB are **187GB** and, with no room for cache, **242GB**. **A 32GB RTX 5090 is not in this conversation.** Where a 5090 is still the best instrument on the bench is at the other end of the scale: **Ollama 0.40.6**, released **16 October**, added a **2.25-bit** tensor type — sixty-four weights in eighteen bytes — which unblocked a ternary 27-billion model that fits in **5.95GB** and runs **129.9 tokens a second** on that card at **1.95 joules a token**.[3]

29 tok/s

A 501B APACHE-2.0 MODEL DECODING ON ONE DESKTOP, MEASURED 18 OCTOBER[2]

IN BRIEF

An independent owner benchmarked the ternary model on a single RTX 5060 Ti, publishing scripts and raw evaluation files: **44.4 against 35.8 tokens a second** versus a conventional two-bit quantisation, and about **2.5× less GPU energy per solved problem** from hardware counters. The honest caveat is the author's own: the accuracy gap at **n=30** was **not significant** (p=0.072).[3]

THE CHATTER · A THREAD THAT MARKED ITS OWN HOMEWORK

The Hacker News thread on Beam ran to **556 points and 173 comments** and caught the lab in a contamination error on its own headline example. **Ariarule**: **"Oof, no, this 'puzzle is a few days old' is incorrect"** — tracing it to a post from August 2025. A company account conceded the team **"did not realize that the trend went that far back"** and revised the caption.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO DOCUMENTS THAT CONTRADICT EACH OTHER

The ternary model's own card says stock llama.cpp **rejects its two newest formats outright and loads the third while producing garbage**, and that a maker's fork is required. The Ollama pull request that shipped on 16 October says the opposite: all four sizes now **create and run** under stock Ollama, with thinking, vision and tools, on Apple Silicon. One of them is stale and the reader will find out the hard way. And on Reflection's own published table Beam scores **44.4** on one agentic coding benchmark where a rival open model scores **74.2** — a pair that appears in the table and not in the headline charts.[4]

SOURCES 1 **The model card on Hugging Face and the laboratory's own launch post, both read at source**, for the parameter counts, the architecture, the context length, the licence, the training tokens and the accelerator count; **the llama.cpp pull request on GitHub, read at source**, for the date opened and merged, the parser and the attention handling. 2 **The streaming repack's own model card, read at source**, for the on-disk size, the machine, the wired-memory setting, the peak footprint, the prompt and generation lengths, both seeds' decode figures, the prefill rate, the time to first token, the draft-lane gain and the author's statement that the lane is lossy and off by default. **No published Beam figure on a Mac through llama.cpp exists; the quantisation author states plainly they have never run their files on a Mac.** 3 A community GGUF repository, read at source, for the full size ladder; **the Ollama release notes and the merged pull request, both read at source**, for the version, the date, the tensor type and the block layout; the ternary model's own card for its size, benchmark table and throughput; and an independent owner's published benchmark, read at source, for the comparison, the memory figures, the energy counters and the significance caveat. 4 **The Hacker News thread, read at source**, for the score, the comment count and every quoted remark under the handle posted, and for the two benchmark pairs, which appear in the laboratory's own published table. **Reddit refused this desk for a sixth consecutive issue, so r/LocalLLaMA is out of evidence and nothing above is attributed to it.**

THE KIT · EVEN REALITIES G2

Engadget scored the Even Realities G2 at 6.9 and preferred the older G1

Daniel Cooper's review ran on 19 October. Even charges Singapore US$649 for the same glasses it sells Americans at US$599, and bills in US dollars.

Engadget published **Daniel Cooper**'s review of the **Even Realities G2** display glasses on **Monday 19 October** and scored them **6.9 out of 10**, recommending them only to **"technically minded buyers with the budget who expect to handle the controls well"** and telling everyone else to wait for the next generation. He says plainly that he prefers the **G1**, the model these replace. A reviewer preferring the predecessor at the same price is the most damaging sentence available about a product, and it is one day old.[1]

The hardware is a real step. The display goes to **640 × 350** from the G1's 640 × 200, the field of view to **27.5 degrees** from 25, the refresh to **60Hz** from 20, and peak brightness to **1,200 nits**. Four microphones instead of two, **IP65**, and **no camera at all** — which is the point of them. The companion **R1** ring is zirconia ceramic, **IP68**, four-day battery, at **US$249**. A second reviewer in June supplied the measurements Cooper did not take: **36 grams** of frame, **44** as worn, a **192mAh** battery good for about five hours.[2]

What fails is the input layer, and two reviewers four months apart failed at the same thing. The ring and the temple pads recognise exactly four gestures — swipe up, swipe down, tap, press. Cooper reports long presses read as swipes and swipes as taps, opening applications by accident. In June **Andy Boxall** had already written that **"taps often register as presses instead of swipes"** and that the ring triggers the touch panel by accident. Cooper offered the clumsy-fingers excuse for himself; Boxall had removed it four months earlier.[2]

WHAT IT COSTS HERE · AND TWO SINGAPORE PRICES THIS BOOK HAS BEEN HOLDING

Even Realities bills Singapore in US dollars and charges more. Its own Singapore storefront lists the G2 at **US$649** against **US$599** on the American one, and single-vision lenses at **US$179** against US$159. The only Singapore-dollar retail channel this desk could verify is **iShopChangi**, at **S$778.90**, marked limited availability — below Even's own Singapore price at prevailing rates, with travel-retail collection rules attached. **No Shopee or Lazada brand store, no Challenger or Courts listing was found.**[3]

The Surface Laptop Ultra now has a Singapore price, after four issues held. Microsoft's Singapore store lists the business SKU from **S$5,979**, in stock: the RTX Spark N1X part, 48GB unified memory, 1TB, against **US$2,599.99** in America, on sale from **16 October**. **Only the business SKU is listed here; no consumer Singapore listing exists.**[4]

And the DGX Spark, held since No. 134, has one too — from a reseller, not NVIDIA. SourceIT lists the 128GB/4TB unit at **S$7,912** with local warranty, against an ASUS equivalent at **S$9,062**. **NVIDIA does not sell direct here, so an official local price may not exist.**[4]

THE CHATTER · THE REVIEWERS ARE THE COMMUNITY HERE

With the usual boards unreachable, the convergence between two independent reviews is the signal. Boxall, who scored the G2 **8**, is colder than Cooper on the add-on: the ring is **hard to recommend**, and anyone who does not already wear glasses should **consider a good smartwatch instead**. He also notes no speakers, so no calls or podcasts; an app store that often failed to install; and a display distracting while driving. **Reddit and The Verge both refused this desk; no forum sentiment is reported and none was invented.**[2]

THE SCEPTIC · BOTH FAILURES ARE SOFTWARE

The case against waiting is that neither fault is in the silicon. Gesture discrimination across four inputs is a classification problem in firmware, not a hardware limit — so a single update could move both the 6.9 and the 8, and the **"wait for the next generation"** advice dies with it. **That is the falsification test, and it is the reason this desk is reporting the review rather than recommending the product.** Note too that the G2 is not new: it shipped in **November 2025**. What is new is that somebody serious has now scored it.[1]

SOURCES 1 **Engadget, 19 October 2026, read at source**, for the score, both quoted recommendations, the preference for the G1, the gesture failures and the November 2025 release. 2 The same review for the display, field-of-view, refresh, brightness, microphone, ingress-rating and ring specifications; **Android Police, 27 June 2026, read at source**, for the measured weights, the battery capacity and life, the quoted gesture complaint and every criticism attributed to that reviewer. 3 **Even Realities' own American and Singapore storefronts, both read at source**, for the two prices and the two lens prices and for the fact that the Singapore locale bills in US dollars; iShopChangi's own listing for the Singapore-dollar price and the availability note. **Searches of the two local marketplaces and two local retailers returned no listing; resale classifieds exist and are not printed as retail prices.** 4 **Microsoft's Singapore store, read directly from the page's own pricing data after its interface refused a normal request**, for the S$5,979 figure, the currency field and the in-stock flag; a hardware title of 8 October for the American price and the on-sale date; **an authorised Singapore reseller's own listing, read the same way**, for all three accelerator prices and the warranty term. These clear two threads held since No. 134.

THE GOOD LIFE · IWC'S LUNAR NEW YEAR

IWC limits its Year of the Goat chronograph to 500 pieces at CHF 10,400

Announced in Schaffhausen on 15 October, four months before the year it marks begins on 6 February 2027. The movement is built by ValFleurier, not in Schaffhausen.

IWC announced the **Pilot's Watch Performance Chronograph 41 "Year of the Goat"**, reference **IW388310**, on **15 October**: **500 pieces**, **CHF 10,400**, **EUR 13,100** with tax, **US$13,100**. A 41mm titanium case, 14.8mm thick, under a black ceramic bezel carrying a fixed tachymeter; 100 metres; a gold-coloured sunburst dial with three black snailed registers. The trick is at three o'clock, where the date disc carries the character 羊 in place of the numeral eight — so the goat appears on the eighth of each month, and twelve days a year the watch tells you what year it is.[1]

The movement is where the question sits. Calibre **69385** is a column-wheel chronograph, **33 jewels**, **28,800 vibrations an hour**, **46 hours** of reserve — and one specialist title states plainly that it is **"manufactured by ValFleurier"**, the group's shared movement arm, rather than in Schaffhausen. Through the sapphire back the rotor is plated and sculpted as three goats on an outcrop; the rim is engraved **"YEAR OF THE GOAT"**, **"2027"**, **"ONE OF 500"**.[2]

The press liked it and said so briefly. **Fratello**'s Robert-Jan Broer called the dial **"chic"** and the whole **"a warm ensemble"**, closing that it **"will easily find its way to 500 customers"** — while conceding he has not worn it and only hopes **"the dial will still be very readable"**. **Monochrome**'s first look found the contrast with the bezel **"works particularly well"**. **No Singapore price is published, and Hodinkee, SJX, aBlogtoWatch, Worn & Wound and Time and Tide have not covered this reference at all.**[3]

羊

THE CHARACTER THAT REPLACES THE NUMERAL 8 ON THE DATE DISC — VISIBLE TWELVE DAYS A YEAR[1]

THE CHATTER · THE COMMENT THREAD DID THE REVIEWING

Under Fratello's own piece the readers were less polite than the copy. **CBalls**, 15 October: **"How is this $14,500 USD??? This is insane. Its an old movement and the dial isn't even real gold."** — his figure is wrong, the American price is $13,100, but the objection is the thread's loudest. **Thomas**, the next morning: **"Why is this so pricey? It's valjoux 7750 base updated with a column wheel..."** **MarkBu** likes it **"if you can live with the cut-off Arabic numerals"** — which the press photograph confirms: the registers clip the 9 and the 12. **Chaz_H**: **"At that price, I'd prefer it be actually numbered instead of just 'One of...'."** And a dozen replies ran on whether the animal is a goat or a ram, settled by a reader noting that 羊 covers both.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT CHF 10,400 IS ACTUALLY BUYING

Strip the zodiac and the specification is a **46-hour, 4Hz, group-built column-wheel chronograph in a titanium case** — a good movement, not a rare one. The premium buys a dial that is gold-coloured rather than gold, a rotor shaped like livestock, and a date trick with a twelve-day duty cycle. The limitation is a number on a caseback, not an individual one. **What would falsify the complaint is simple and testable: if the 500 pieces clear at full retail into Greater China before 6 February, the objection is academic and the thread was wrong.**[2]

SOURCES 1 IWC's own press images and the maker's reference, together with two specialist titles' launch pieces of 15 October 2026, all read at source, for the reference number, the limitation, all three prices, the case dimensions, the water resistance, the bezel and dial description and the date-disc character. The dial layout above — the register positions and the clipped numerals — was read off the maker's own photograph by this desk before it was captioned. 2 Two specialist titles of 15 October 2026, read at source, for the calibre number, the jewel count, the frequency, the power reserve, the quoted ValFleurier attribution and every caseback engraving. 3 Fratello and Monochrome, both 15 October 2026, read at source, for all five quoted judgements. A domain-restricted search of five further specialist titles returned only earlier Performance Chronograph variants, not this reference; no Singapore price was found at any source and none is printed. 4 The comment thread beneath Fratello's piece, 15 and 16 October 2026, read at source and quoted under the handles posted. The American price correction is this desk's, against the figure the commenter used. A German forum thread reported to carry a similar complaint returned 403 and is not quoted. Reddit refused this desk for a sixth consecutive issue, so no collector-forum sentiment appears above.

SCREEN & SOUND · HARLEM, 1972

Neon opened William Greaves's 1972 Harlem film on two screens at $34,153 each

Shot on 16mm at Duke Ellington's Harlem home in August 1972 and finished by his son David, it holds 100 per cent from 55 critics and a Metascore of 93.

Neon released **Once Upon a Time in Harlem** into **two** American cinemas on **Friday 16 October**, and it took **$68,307 — $34,153 a screen**. In the same weekend **Street Fighter** took **$31 million** from **3,575** screens, which is **$8,671** each, and A24's Elizabeth Holmes documentary took **$15 million** from 855, or $17,543. A fifty-four-year-old reel of party footage out-earned the weekend's number one, per screen, by very nearly four to one.[1]

What is on the reel is the reason. In **August 1972** the documentarian **William Greaves** staged a party at **Duke Ellington's home in Harlem** and filmed it on **16mm** with a crew that included his then **26-year-old son David**. The guests were the surviving figures of the Harlem Renaissance, many of whom had not seen each other in about fifty years: **Eubie Blake**, **Richard Bruce Nugent**, **Ida Mae Cullen**, **Gerri Major**, the photographer **James Van Der Zee**; the painter **Aaron Douglas** and the librarian **Jean Blackwell Hutson** appear in the film. Greaves never finished it. His son did.[2]

The reviews are at the top of the scale. **Rotten Tomatoes: 100 per cent from 55 critics**, the consensus calling it **"a strikingly immersive glimpse into a unique time and place"**. **Metacritic: 93 from 15**, with Rolling Stone, The Hollywood Reporter, Screen Daily and The Film Stage all at 100 and Variety at 90. One trade note is worth more than the scores: the film is reported to be the only title to have screened at **Sundance, Cannes, Telluride, Toronto, New York and London** in the same year. **Liani Greaves**, who produced: **"We think about this film as like a recipe for an awakening."**[3]

ALSO THIS WEEKEND

Street Fighter took the weekend with **$31m** on a Metascore of **44 from 26** and **41 per cent from 111** critics — against a **79 per cent** audience score. The split is the story: Empire's Helen O'Hara allows that the cast are **"in on the joke and having fun with it"**; RogerEbert.com's Clint Worthington notes **"The punishing two-hour runtime ends in a flagrant call for a sequel."**[4]

Fontaines D.C.'s Dopamine Chamber, released 16 October, stands at a Metascore of **85 from 19**. **No chart position exists yet**: the British albums chart covering that week publishes on **23 October** and the American one on **25 October**, both after this issue. **No. 137's held projection of 88,000 units could not be sourced anywhere this week and is dropped rather than repeated.**[5]

THE CHATTER · NINE FANS AND A TREASURE

The audience sample is tiny and honest about it. Letterboxd shows the film with **nine fans** and too few ratings to average. The most-liked entry, **SilentDawn** at four and a half stars with **83 likes**: it **"Does the job of any great archival work, connecting us to the complications of the past."** Another, **Ryan**: **"this was one of the most moving things I've ever seen..."** A third, three words: **"A miracle movie."** On two screens there is no mass audience yet to disagree, and this desk is not going to manufacture one.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO SCREENS IS NOT A VERDICT

A per-screen average on **two** cinemas is the least robust number in exhibition. It measures a New York opening weekend with a filmmaker in the room, not demand. The honest comparison on the same chart is a Netflix awards-qualifying run that took **$69,375** from four screens — higher still, and meaning nothing at all. **The test is the expansion:** if Neon widens the release and the average holds above the low thousands, this is a picture with an audience; if it collapses, the $34,153 was two full houses of people who already knew who William Greaves was. **Nobody can answer that for another fortnight.**[1]

SOURCES 1 **Box Office Mojo's weekend chart for 16–18 October 2026, read at source**, for every gross, theatre count and per-theatre average above, including the Netflix qualifying run. **The four-to-one comparison is this desk's arithmetic on the published figures.** 2 An American outlet's feature of 28 September 2026, read at source, for the August 1972 date, the Ellington house, the 16mm format, the son's age and crew role, and every guest named; a film trade title of 3 September 2026, read at source, for the four-hour party and the fifty-year gap. 3 **Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic, both read at source**, for both aggregate scores, both review counts, the quoted consensus and the individual outlet scores; the six-festival claim is the film trade title's, read at source and attributed to it. The producer's quotation is from the 28 September feature. 4 **Metacritic and Rotten Tomatoes, read at source**, for both scores and both counts, and the two critics' quoted lines as displayed there. 5 **Metacritic's music pages returned 403 on four separate URL forms, as did a second aggregator, so the 85-from-19 figure is single-sourced through a search index and is flagged as such.** The two chart dates are the charts' own published schedules. 6 Letterboxd, read at source, for the fan count, the absence of an average and all three quoted reviews under the handles posted. **The page does not display review dates and none is given here.**

THE FAMILY DESK · THE FIRST PHONE

A study in Frontiers tracked 3,486 children through their first smartphone year

Published 30 September in Frontiers in Child and Adolescent Psychiatry, it found tripled odds of a social media account and school-night sleep down a fifth of a standard deviation.

A paper published on **30 September 2026** in Frontiers in Child and Adolescent Psychiatry did something unusually well matched to this household: it took **3,486** American children who ***did not yet own a smartphone at twelve*** and followed them to thirteen. Every model adjusted for the same measure taken before the phone arrived, which is what separates it from the correlational noise this desk usually has to discount.[1]

The effects are real, consistent in sign, and small. Internalising symptoms rose **0.11 of a standard deviation** (confidence interval 0.05 to 0.18); attention problems **0.09** (0.03–0.16); total problems **0.10** (0.04–0.17). School-night sleep ***fell* 0.18** (−0.25 to −0.11). Total screen time rose **0.19**. The one large number is not a symptom at all: the odds of owning a social media account were **3.22 times higher** (2.66–3.91). And the biggest coefficient in the whole paper is **bedtime social media use, at 0.42** (0.35–0.49).[1]

The phone is the delivery vehicle. The payload is an account and a lit screen at bedtime.

Then read what did not move, because it is half the finding. **No association with externalising behaviour, with academic performance, with exercise, or with bullying or cyberbullying** — all above the significance threshold. The mediation analysis says the mental-health association ran indirectly, through screen time, account ownership and bedtime use, which together accounted for most of it, with social media the largest single path. So the lever is not the handset.[1]

The authors' own limitations belong beside the numbers. **"Causal conclusions cannot be definitively established"**; the window was **a single one-year interval**; and the obvious confound is conceded — families who hold a phone back until thirteen are not the same families as those who do not. The senior author sits, unpaid, on a children-and-screens advisory board and holds equity in a health company. **Print the interests with the effect sizes.**[2]

OR 3.22

ODDS OF OWNING A SOCIAL MEDIA ACCOUNT IN THE YEAR AFTER THE FIRST PHONE (2.66–3.91)[1]

THE CHATTER · SINGAPORE'S GUIDANCE EXPIRES ON HER BIRTHDAY

The health ministry's own screen-use guidance, read at source, stops at twelve. For **7 to 12** it says: **"Limit screen use to less than 2 hours a day, unless related to schoolwork"**; **"Do not use screens during meals and one hour before bedtime"**; and, flatly, **"Parents should not give your child access to social media services. The advisory and the risk change hands at the same moment.**[3]

THE SCEPTIC · THE ARROW MAY POINT THE OTHER WAY

Candice Odgers' group published in the Journal of Research on Adolescence in September using passively logged phone data rather than self-report — 3,192 daily observations from 40 adolescents over 90 days, separating active from passive use. When they reported higher-than-usual morning negative mood, they used their phones more passively that same day; and daily fluctuations in use "did not predict sleep that night or next-morning affect". Mood shaped the phone, not the reverse. Two honest caveats: n is forty, and they are aged 15 to 20 — this is a directionality argument, not a finding about a twelve-year-old. A co-author holds equity in the firm licensing the measurement app.[4]

SOURCES 1 Bren, Tran, Clinton, Visoki, Tran, Michel, Moore, Pimentel and Barzilay, "Smartphone acquisition as an inflection point in early adolescence digital exposome", Frontiers in Child and Adolescent Psychiatry 5:1940646, published 30 September 2026, open access and read in full at source, for the cohort definition, both group sizes, the pre-exposure adjustment, every coefficient and confidence interval, every null result and the mediation analysis. 2 The same paper, for all four quoted limitations and the declared interests and funding. General guidance, not medical advice. 3 The Ministry of Health's own "Guidance on Screen Use in Children", downloaded as its PDF and read at source, for all three quoted recommendations for the 7-to-12 band and the age statement about social media services. Reports that the education ministry extended its secondary-school phone restrictions in January 2026 reached this desk only through search summaries; no primary source was read and nothing is printed from them. 4 Chen, Lind, Ram and Odgers, "Adolescents' daily affect predicts their mobile phone use (not the other way around)", Journal of Research on Adolescence 36(3):e70255, September 2026, abstract read at source, for the observation count, the sample size and age band, the active/passive separation, the direction of the finding, the quoted null and the declared interest.

THE TWEEN YEARS · BEDTIME

Sleep Health finds Florida children slept worse using a phone in bed

Published in Sleep Health on 10 October, it reports odds of trouble sleeping up to thirteen times higher for children who use the phone in bed.

The counter-intuitive result of the month comes from Bakour and colleagues in Sleep Health on 10 October 2026: among 1,510 children aged 11 to 13 surveyed in Florida, owning a smartphone was associated with lower odds of insufficient sleep and of trouble sleeping. What raised both was behaviour — the phone in bed, posting publicly, more than two hours on it in the evening, cyberbullying. Using the phone in bed showed the strongest association, with odds up to thirteen times higher for trouble sleeping. The authors' conclusion: "how smartphones are used, rather than merely owning one, has substantial implications for sleep."[1]

Put that beside p12 and the practical instruction writes itself, and it is narrower than the usual advice. The target is not the screen. It is the hour before sleep and the room it happens in. In the Frontiers cohort bedtime social media use carried the largest coefficient in the entire study; academic performance, exercise and bullying did not move at all. Separating the phone from the bedroom is the intervention with the most evidence behind it this month, and it survives the contrarian on p12, whose argument concerns mood and daytime use, not the bed.[2]

THREE FURTHER FINDINGS, EACH READ AT SOURCE

The bidirectional one. Pediatrics published on 19 October a cross-lagged analysis of 11,279 children, mean age 12.01 at baseline. It found two-way associations between problematic social media use and depressive symptoms in two of four intervals — and none at all for anxiety. The effect sizes are held: the journal refused this desk and the abstract publishes no numbers.[3]

The reassuring null. A marginal-structural analysis of 7,489 children published on 8 October found no effect of chronotype at 11 to 12 on anything. Being a night owl at 12 to 13 produced only small effects a year later — externalising behaviour b = 0.29, psychotic-like experiences b = 0.05 — and no effect on internalising symptoms, with the null holding for anxiety and depression separately and in both sexes. The authors suggest the familiar night-owl link "may not manifest until later adolescence".[4]

The one about school sport. A cluster-randomised trial across 30 Danish schools and 1,652 pupils aged 10 to 13 ran three high-intensity sessions a week for forty weeks. Fitness improved by 54.90 metres on the shuttle test (8.35 to 101.40, p = 0.021). But there was no effect on quality of life, physical self-concept or motivation. School PE moved her fitness; it did not move how she felt about herself.[5]

7,489

CHILDREN IN THE CHRONOTYPE ANALYSIS THAT FOUND NO EFFECT AT ALL AT ELEVEN TO TWELVE[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE NUMBERS MEAN IN ENGLISH

A tenth of a standard deviation on a symptom scale is not a child becoming unwell; it is a small shift in a whole distribution, which matters at population scale and is close to invisible in one household. The honest summary for a parent is that the research describes a modest, consistent nudge, not a cliff — and that its single largest number is about a social media account, which is the one thing in the chain a parent can still decide. Every effect above is an association. None of the designs can establish cause, and all of their authors say so.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · A CROSS-SECTION CANNOT TELL YOU WHICH CAME FIRST

The Florida study is cross-sectional, self-reported and single-state, so its headline runs both ways: children who sleep badly may reach for the phone in bed rather than the other way round — precisely the arrow Odgers' group found on p12. Its individual odds ratios and their confidence intervals are held, not verified: the publisher refused this desk and the paper is in neither open repository. Two of the four findings on this page therefore rest on abstracts, and are printed as abstracts. General guidance, not medical advice.[1]

SOURCES 1 Bakour and colleagues, "Smartphones, digital media use, and sleep in young adolescents", Sleep Health, published 10 October 2026, abstract read at source via the national library's index, for the sample size, the age band, the survey, the direction of the ownership finding, every named behaviour, the quoted thirteen-fold figure and the quoted conclusion. The full text was refused and the individual odds ratios and intervals are held. 2 The Frontiers paper at p12 note 1, for the bedtime coefficient, the sleep effect and the null results. 3 Nagata and colleagues, Pediatrics, published online 19 October 2026, abstract read at source, for the sample size, the mean age, the design, the two intervals, the anxiety null and the sex differences. The journal returned 403 and the abstract reports no effect sizes; none is printed. 4 Visontay, Hickie, Crouse and colleagues, Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry, 8 October 2026, abstract read at source, for the sample size, the design, both coefficients, every null and the quoted suggestion. 5 Cimenti, Krustrup, Ntoumanis and colleagues, Scandinavian Journal of Medicine & Science in Sports 36(10):e70374, abstract read at source, for the school and pupil counts, the age band, the protocol, the shuttle-test effect with its interval and p-value, the secondary gains, every psychological null and the quoted concession.

THE MACRO DESK · THE PASS-THROUGH

American energy prices rose 20.4% to September while the Fed kept raising

Global equities and global bonds both fell on Monday 19 October as all three Treasury yields rose. The 2s10s curve steepened back to 38 basis points.

The Bureau of Labor Statistics published September's consumer prices on Wednesday 14 October: headline +0.6 per cent on the month and 3.7 on the year, core +0.3 and 2.6. One line explains the rest of this page and part of p3. "The index for energy increased 5.2 percent in September after rising 2.1 percent in August" — 20.4 per cent higher than a year ago. Hormuz is not a foreign story with a market read-through. It is the largest single component of the American inflation print.[1]

The Federal Reserve is raising into that. The target range is 3.75 to 4.00 per cent after a 25 basis-point increase on 17 September. Aditya Bhave of Bank of America, on Monday: "Most of the FOMC was on board with two hikes this year." The committee is in blackout until 27–28 October.[2]

The curve has turned again. 2s10s went +44, then +35 on 16 October, and on Monday back to +38 — a bear steepening, with the two-year up 3 basis points, the ten-year 6 and the thirty-year 5 to 5.48. The bull flattening of No. 137 lasted a week. At 38 basis points the curve is still flat: a market pricing tightening now and damage later.[3]

Singapore sits on the other side of that divergence. MAS held on 14 October after tightening in April and July: "For now, the risks to inflation remain tilted to the upside." Third-quarter growth was 5.4 per cent and core inflation has climbed from 1.5 to 2.1. A paused MAS against a hiking Fed is why USD/SGD at 1.2787 is the quiet number on the board.[4]

THE BOARD · MONDAY 19 OCTOBER CLOSE

INSTRUMENT	LEVEL	DAY
VWRA	$191.58	▼ 0.05%
US 10-year	5.15%	▲ 6bp
Brent (Dec)	~$109	▼ 0.1%
Gold (spot)	$4,140.52	▼ 0.60%
Bitcoin	~$82,000	▲ 1.1%
STI	5,412.00	▼ 0.07%

The 2-year closed 4.77% (up 3bp), the 30-year 5.48%, global bonds $5.76, DXY 102.00, USD/SGD 1.2787, the STI 5,412.00. Brent and bitcoin are rounded: two services disagreed on contract and snapshot time. Not advice.[5]

+20.4%

AMERICAN ENERGY PRICES, YEAR TO SEPTEMBER — THE NUMBER CONNECTING HORMUZ, THE FED AND THE FRENCH STREET[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE FOUR

Both legs fell together on Monday. Global equities −0.05 per cent, global bonds −0.35, every Treasury yield up: diversification failing, for the textbook reason. BlackRock named the mechanism in April: "Supply-side disruptions can have the opposite effect, with bond prices falling and yields rising." Gold is the puzzle: it fell 0.60 per cent to $4,140 during a shooting war in the world's main oil chokepoint, because at a 5.15 ten-year the carrying cost beats the haven bid.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · THE PRINT THAT DECIDES IT

The regime rests on whether the oil shock stays in energy. Michigan's one-year inflation expectations land on Friday, forecast 4.7 per cent. A five-handle and the transitory argument is dead. Rate-odds percentages for the October meeting circulated between 27 and 44 per cent; this desk could read none at a primary venue and prints none.[7]

SOURCES 1 **The Bureau of Labor Statistics' own September consumer-price release, read at source at bls.gov**, for every headline and core figure, the quoted energy sentence and the 20.4 per cent annual energy change. 2 **The Federal Reserve's own open-market operations page, read at source**, for the target range and the 17 September increase; a market wire's live file of 19 October, read at source, for the Bank of America economist's quoted line and for the blackout and meeting dates. 3 **The US Treasury's own daily par yield curve file, read row by row**, for the 2-, 10- and 30-year levels on 16 and 19 October and every change and spread computed from them. The spread arithmetic is this desk's. 4 **The Monetary Authority of Singapore's own statement of 14 October 2026, read at source**, for the quotation, the growth and core-inflation figures and the tightening history. 5 VWRA and AGGU from a market-data service's stamped quotes, corroborated against a second; DXY, USD/SGD, Brent, gold and bitcoin from two services apiece, flagged in the caption where they disagreed; the Straits Times Index double-sourced and date-stamped. **Widely-circulated central-bank gold tonnages could not be read at the World Gold Council and are not printed.** 7 An economic-calendar preview of 19 October 2026, read at source. **Forecasts are flagged as forecasts and nothing here is investment advice.**. 6 BlackRock's published 60/40 analysis of 30 April 2026, read at source, for the quoted mechanism and the 17-of-19 figure. 7 An economic-calendar preview of 19 October 2026, read at source. **Forecasts are flagged as forecasts and nothing here is investment advice.**

THE INVITATION · STEEL FRAMEBUILDING

Bespoked brings the handmade-bicycle show to Osaka on Friday with 70-plus makers

It is the show's first Asian edition, three days from now, six and a half hours from Changi. Advance tickets close on Thursday 22 October.

Framebuilding is cutting steel tubes and joining them with heat. Three things are hard. **Mitering** — cutting a saddle-shaped end so two tubes sit together with no gap. **Joining** — melting filler in without cooking walls that can be **0.38 millimetres** thick. And **alignment**, because heat pulls steel out of true as it cools. A frame's worth of the best steel costs about **US$300 to $400**; everything else is labour, tooling and paint.[1]

On **Friday 23 October** this world arrives in Asia for the first time. **Bespoked** opens at the **GLION Museum in Minato Ward, Osaka**, running to Sunday, with **"70+ independent makers and brands"** — among them **Cherubim**, whose Konno workshop is one of Japan's great frame shops, plus **Nitto**, **Tange Seiki**, **MKS**, **Izumi Chain**, **Honjo**, **Grand Bois**, **Blue Lug**, **Vigore**, **Sim Works** and the Tokyo College of Cycle Design. **Advance tickets close Thursday 22 October** and the door costs more. The organiser's stated aim is to **"create a frame-building hub in Asia"**.[2]

Between 2020 and 2026 this craft lost both its major schools, its biggest American parts maker, its biggest British one, its lug supplier and its tubing importer.

It arrives at the end of a demolition. **Henry James**, which made lugs and dropouts, closed in **May 2020**; **Nova Cycles**, the main American Columbus importer, ceased operations in **2022**. **The Bicycle Academy** in Frome went into liquidation around **10 November 2022**, its founder citing a **"perfect storm"** of covid, Brexit, supply chains and energy prices: **"we couldn't make it add up."** The **United Bicycle Institute**'s framebuilding programme is simply gone — its class list is mechanics only. **Mercian** of Derby went into liquidation in **May 2024** after **78 years**, and was rescued a month later.[3]

Then the two biggest. **Paragon Machine Works** of Richmond, California — the dropouts and fittings in a generation of American frames — announced on **27 March 2026**, after **43 years**, that it would **"cease all major operations"** because **"our business is no longer viable"**. In **August 2026**, **Bear Frame Supplies** in the Peak District closed, its owners citing **"Diminishing demand, issues sourcing raw materials"**.[4]

70+

MAKERS AT BESPOKED OSAKA. THERE IS NO TRADE BODY WITH A HEADCOUNT: THE NEAREST CENSUS IS **93 FRAMEBUILDERS** AMONG 156 EXHIBITORS AT DRESDEN IN 2025, AND **"OVER 1,000 BUILDERS"** ON THE FRAMEBUILDERS LIST[2][5]

THE SCEPTIC · OR IT IS BEING REBUILT BY DIFFERENT PEOPLE

On **21 May 2026**, **Firsthand Framebuilding** of Portland — already the North American distributor for Reynolds — bought **"the entirety of"** Paragon's intellectual property: the designs, the trademarks and **"all of the associated tooling"**. Its owner, Chris Blandford: **"What we've bought here isn't an operating business we hope to fix or replicate."** Then it did the thing that decides the next decade. From its own status page: **"all of the Paragon design files will be freely available for download and personal use"**, to keep that legacy **"perpetually available to independent builders"**. And it opens a school in November. **The craft was not dying; it was being taken apart and reassembled by someone else.**[6]

SOURCES *1 Builders' and suppliers' own technical pages and course catalogues, read at source, for the three operations, the wall thickness and the tubeset cost band. 2* ***Bespoked's own Osaka page, read at source****, for the dates, the venue, the quoted maker count, the exhibitor list every name is taken from, the awards hour and the ticket deadline; a cycling title's interview for the quoted aim.* ***No ticket price is published there, so none is printed.*** *3 A mountain-bike title and a cycling-industry title, both read at source, for the Bicycle Academy's liquidation and its founder's quoted remarks; the institute's own class list and site map, which contain no framebuilding page.* ***The Henry James and Nova closures and the Mercian rescue are single-sourced through trade coverage; the parked Nova domain was checked directly.*** *4* ***Paragon's own statement as carried by a bikepacking title, read at source****, for the date, the 43 years and both quoted sentences; a British cycling title of 13 August 2026, read at source, for Bear's closure, its owners' quoted reason and the builder's quoted remark. 5 A German cycling magazine's Dresden report, read at source, for the breakdown and attendance; a trade release of 3 September 2026 for the MADE figures,* ***which that outlet states it does not fact-check****; the Framebuilders group's own page for the membership quotation. 6* ***Firsthand's own Paragon status page and two cycling titles' reports of the May 2026 purchase, all read at source****, for the acquisition, its scope, both quoted statements and the licensing intention.*

THE DEEP END · REYNOLDS 953

The maraging stainless Reynolds 953 is discontinued, and the joining argument is dying

A frame's worth of premium tube runs from £188.95 delivered to about US$400. The argument about how you join it is quietly dying.

Start where the money is not. A complete tube kit from a British supplier, with brazing rod and flux, is **£188.95 delivered**; a Columbus set plus lugs about **€327**. The tubing names are the liturgy — Reynolds **531**, **753**, **853**, **931**; Columbus **SL** and **Spirit** — and the trophy, the maraging stainless **953**, is discontinued. The conversation is now about **931**, **XCr** and KVA, and about a narrow brazing window where ***a mistake often cannot be fixed.***[1]

The community that argues about this is partly a ruin, and the ruin is part of the culture now. The **Framebuilders list** — 1990s, ***"over 1,000 builders"***, now a moderated Google Group — is the elders' room: slow, text-only and allergic to anyone who has not read the archive. But ***framebuilders.com is a parked domain for sale***; the **Velocipede Salon**, whose builder interviews are the deepest first-person writing on the craft anywhere, refuses every request and is now an archive you read rather than a room you join. **Weight Weenies** and the **Bike Forums** board did the same here.[2]

Where the craft actually performs itself now is YouTube and Instagram. **Paul Brodie**, a Mountain Bike Hall of Fame builder, started a weekly instructional channel during the pandemic and teaches in person at the University of the Fraser Valley. **Cobra Framebuilding** claims ***"over 100 YouTube videos and 50 podcast interviews about framebuilding"*** — and sells the fixtures too, which makes it teacher, broadcaster and toolmaker at once. The commissioning world lives on builders' Instagram: **Richard Sachs**'s homepage is a wall of embeds tagged **#hautеframebuilding**. The genre is fixed — finished frame, raking light, no rider.[3]

£188.95

A COMPLETE TUBE KIT, DELIVERED, WITH BRAZING ROD AND FLUX — THE ENTIRE MATERIAL COST OF A FRAME[1]

WHAT A BENCH COSTS, IN THE ORDER YOU WOULD BUY IT

The jig is the first real decision. A documented DIY fixture comes to **$500–600** plus a **$100** stand and **$70** of stay-mitering fixtures. A commercial fixture is **$3,995 to $5,475**; a professional one **$9,500**. Reaming and facing add **$542.25**; a TIG machine runs **$849** to **$16,500**.[4]

Paint is the grievance. Builders call it the longest-lead and most complaint-generating part of the job, and it can be a third of the build cost. ***The one datum this desk could reach — that custom paint programmes need several times the usual price once comebacks are counted — is single-sourced through a search index.***[4]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO BUILDERS WHO CHARGE NOTHING FOR THE THING YOU ARE BUYING

The custom pitch rests on geometry cut to your body — so note what it costs. ***Pegoretti's own purchasing page: "There is no extra charge for a custom geometry."*** English Cycles includes ***"custom geometry and design"*** in its **$3,200** base price. ***Two independent custom builders price it at zero*** — as close to an admission as this trade gets that you are paying for the frame, the finish and the name. A builder in the forums puts the rest of it plainly: with the range of stock geometry now available he can ***"fit most people with a stock frame"***.[5]

SOURCES *1 A British supplier's complete-kit listing and a European supplier's tube-and-lug prices, both read at source, for the material costs; makers' own pages for the designations. 2 The Framebuilders group's own description page, read at source, for the membership quotation and the moderation rule; the parked framebuilders.com redirect was checked directly.* ***Velocipede Salon, Weight Weenies and the Bike Forums board all returned 403 to this desk and are characterised rather than quoted.*** *3 A bicycle trade title of 16 July 2020, read at source, for Brodie's channel; Cobra's own site for its quoted counts; Richard Sachs's homepage for the hashtag.* ***Subscriber figures for that channel are years old and none is printed.*** *4 A community workshop's build list of 13 November 2020 and three toolmakers' own price pages, all read at source. 5* ***Pegoretti's and English Cycles' own purchasing pages, both read at source****, for both quoted statements and the base price; the builder's remark is forum material, single-sourced as above.*

THE DEEP END · THE NINETY DAYS

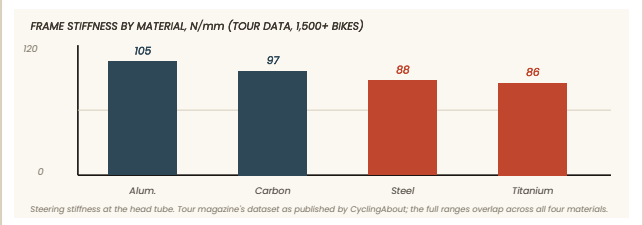
Firsthand charges US$3,800 for ten days that end with a frame you built yourself

There is no framebuilding school in Singapore, no hobbyist brazing class and nowhere legal to run an acetylene torch in a flat. The nearest door opens in Osaka on Friday.

Price the ladder honestly and it is shorter than it looks. **Lurking costs nothing**. A **two-day brazing taster** in Portland is **US$900**, or **$1,100** for TIG,. **Ten days** of Framebuilding 1 is **US$3,800 to $4,100** and you leave with a ready-to-paint steel frame. That is the best-value purchase in the subject: the skill, the frame, and the certainty of whether you want this, for less than a mid-range carbon frameset.[1]

The Singapore answer is blunt and this desk is not going to dress it up. **There is no framebuilding school here, no hobbyist brazing class and no open-access metal shop with oxy-fuel.** What exists is a bicycle assembly workshop at **S$1,300** for four hours on a pre-made frame, and industrial welding certification — the national research agency runs a **45-hour** module covering torch and furnace brazing at **S$3,000** before funding, which teaches brazing metallurgy to an aerospace standard and nothing about bicycles. The one local lead is **Loue Bicycle**'s **Timothy Lim**, who began by brazing steel and exhibited in 2017. **A nine-year-old source; his status is unverified.**[2]

And the flat is a real obstacle, not a fussy one. Oxy-fuel brazing means two compressed-gas cylinders — one of them acetylene, dissolved in acetone and required to stay upright — an open flame at **3,000°C**, flux fumes and a bench long enough for a **1,200mm** jig. In an HDB flat that is not a hobby; it is a fire-safety incident with a management-committee letter attached. **So the ninety-day plan is read for thirty days, fly to Osaka on Friday, and book a course abroad — in that order, and buy nothing.**[2]



Steel is about sixteen per cent less stiff at the head tube than aluminium — and statistically indistinguishable from titanium. **Meridian original, from Tour magazine's dataset as published by CyclingAbout; the figures are second-hand and attributed as such.**[3]

US$3,800

TEN DAYS IN PORTLAND, ENDING WITH A COMPLETE READY-TO-PAINT STEEL FRAME[1]

THE CHATTER · THE MAN WITH THE FAMOUS WAITLIST SAYS BUY FEWER TOOLS

Richard Sachs, whose order book was once ten years long, wrote a piece called Downsize The Fantasy that every beginner should read before spending anything. **"Equipment is nice, but it's not a substitute for a procedure." "tools don't make the frame."** For the first few dozen frames, sophisticated tooling **"will more likely stymie you than help"**. Buy expensive equipment early, he warns, and you will be selling it **"when the dream fades"**.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · NOBODY WILL TELL YOU WHAT THEY EARN

This desk searched for a framebuilder's income and found no survey, no trade figure and no published data anywhere. One maker's own job posting offers **"a competitive hourly wage and benefits relative to other small businesses"** with no rate attached. Not a dying craft — a small one that keeps finding new rooms.[5]

NEXT DESCENTS

Amateur mycology — spore prints, home cultivation, and hobbyists sequencing their own finds.

Violin making — a three-hundred-year varnish argument, and a blind test nobody wanted.

Sheepdog trialling — a century of bloodline politics and five-figure dogs at Skipton.

SOURCES 1 **Firsthand Framebuilding's own course catalogue, read at source**, for every course, its length, its price, the student-to-instructor ratio and the statement that materials and safety equipment are provided; the Framebuilders group's own page and a builder's own channel for the free tier. 2 A Singapore operator's own listing for the assembly session; **the national research agency's own course page, read at source**, for the module, hours and fee; a cycling title of 28 March 2017 for the Singapore builder. **Searches for a local school, hobbyist brazing class or open-access metal shop returned nothing; the flat-safety reasoning is this desk's own.** 3 Tour magazine's stiffness dataset of more than 1,500 road and gravel bikes, **as summarised by a cycling-technical site on 26 February 2021 and read there, not read off Tour's own tables**; Tour's own method pages were read at source to confirm the test's history and basis. **The figures are second-hand and attributed in the caption.** 4 **Richard Sachs's own essay, read at source on his site**, for all four quoted passages, the frame counts and the distance to an alignment table. 5 A framebuilder's own job posting for the quoted wage language; the summit's own page for its purpose and raffle funding.

FITNESS · THE ETHOS STUDY

The ETHOS study priced one MET of fitness at 16 per cent of mortality

Published on 6 October in Medicine & Science in Sports & Exercise, it reports ten-year mortality of 32.9 per cent in the unfit against 13.4 in the fit.

Myers, Kokkinos and colleagues published the ETHOS reclassification analysis on **6 October 2026** in Medicine & Science in Sports & Exercise: **562,234 adults** with complete covariates, mean follow-up **10.2 years**, fitness measured as peak METs on a treadmill. Each additional MET carried a **16 per cent lower hazard of death — HR 0.84**, confidence interval 0.838 to 0.842. Adjusted ten-year all-cause mortality ran **32.9 per cent in the unfit against 13.4 in the fit.**[1]

The paper's actual claim is narrower than that headline and more interesting. It asks whether fitness reclassifies risk beyond the standard variables — age, sex, hypertension, diabetes, lipids, smoking. Adding it moved the concordance statistic from **0.662 to 0.682**, a gain of **0.020**; categorical net reclassification was **0.06**, continuous **0.37**. A real improvement in discrimination, and a modest one.[1]

Now the limitations, which matter more than usual. ETHOS is a retrospective cohort of **United States veterans** given a maximal treadmill test in Veterans Affairs hospitals between **1999 and 2020**; a sibling paper puts the sex split at about **6.5 per cent women**. People are referred for such a test because something is wrong, so reverse causation cannot be excluded by this design. And "unfit" means the least-fit fifth, **below 5.0 METs** — roughly brisk walking up a slight incline. **A mid-forties reader with a trainer is nowhere near it, and the study says nothing about the margin between fit and very fit.**[2]

ΔC 0.020

THE ACTUAL GAIN IN DISCRIMINATION FROM ADDING FITNESS TO THE STANDARD RISK MODEL — REAL, AND MODEST[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE LONGEVITY WORLD SAYS, AND WHAT IT ELIDES

Peter Attia's own published show notes state that cardiorespiratory fitness **"outperforms every other commonly measured variable"** as a predictor of all-cause mortality, that moving from the bottom quartile to the 25th-to-50th band is **"associated with a 50% reduction in all-cause mortality"**, and from there to above average **"closer to 70%"**. He frames the project as maintaining **"optionality around being physical for as long as possible"**. **His interval prescription sits behind a paywall and is not printed. ETHOS has no press coverage at all: this desk found nothing written about it.**[3]

THE SCEPTIC · YOU ARE NOT OPTIMISING THE THING THAT WAS MEASURED

Eric Topol, writing in February, lands squarely on this study and cuts both ways. **"nearly all the data we have for link to outcomes comes from CRF, not V02 max"** — which is exactly right about ETHOS, where the instrument was **peak METs on a treadmill**. On the wrist: the devices **"consistently underestimate V02 in fit people while overestimate in unfit individuals"**. And on the discourse above, bluntly: Attia **"cites all of the studies of CRF without measuring V02 max and extrapolates to a V02 max result"**, and of the claim that it is the single strongest predictor of lifespan, **"Attia's assertion is false."** The usable line: the evidence is good; the number on your ring is not the number in the paper.[4]

WHAT TO ACTUALLY DO, AND WHAT THE TRIAL REALLY FOUND

The Norwegian four-by-four, twice a week: four four-minute efforts near ninety per cent of peak heart rate, three minutes easy between. It is the best-tested way to raise peak METs — and the one five-year randomised trial that tried to show it saves lives **did not reach significance**. Generation 100 randomised **1,567 Norwegians aged 70 to 77**: against controls the interval arm showed **HR 0.63, 0.33 to 1.20**; against moderate training **0.51, 0.25 to 1.02**. Not medical advice.[5]

SOURCES 1 **Myers, Kokkinos and colleagues, "Cardiorespiratory Fitness Reclassifies Mortality Risk Beyond Traditional Risk Factors: The ETHOS Study", Medicine & Science in Sports & Exercise, 6 October 2026**, abstract read at source, for the sample, follow-up, instrument, hazard ratio and interval, both reclassification indices, both concordance statistics and both mortality figures. **Single-sourced to the journal record; no coverage of it exists anywhere.** 2 Three sibling ETHOS papers from the same cohort, read at source, for the cohort's identity, the hospital setting, the 1999–2020 window and the sex split; the MET threshold is the paper's own definition. **The referral-bias and reverse-causation points are this desk's reading of the design, stated as such.** 3 A longevity podcast's own published show notes of 12 January 2026, read at source, for all four quoted passages. 4 **Eric Topol, "The Flawed VO2 Max Craze", Ground Truths, 23 February 2026, read at source**, for all four quoted passages. 5 **Stensvold and colleagues, BMJ 2020**, abstract read at a European open repository after the journal refused this desk, for the randomisation, arm sizes, age band, both hazard ratios with intervals and the authors' explanation of the control group's behaviour. **General guidance, not medical advice.**

THE DIARY · BOOKING THIS WEEK

Bespoked opens in Osaka on Friday and advance tickets close on Thursday

The handmade-bicycle show's first Asian edition runs 23–25 October with 70-plus makers. Tokyo Marathon volunteer entry opens 4 November and closes on the 15th.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

1–30 Oct — **Popaholic 2026**
ESPLANADE PUBLIC SPACES · **29 EVENTS, ALL FREE**, NO BOOKING · ENDS IN TEN DAYS

31 OCT — ★ **Jujutsu Kaisen in Concert**
ESPLANADE THEATRE, 3PM AND 8PM · **FROM S$58**, VIP S$199 · **ADMISSION FROM AGE 6**, ADVISORY 16

14 NOV — **Jeremy Monteiro · 50 Years in Jazz**
ESPLANADE CONCERT HALL · ANNOUNCED ON THE TICKETER'S OWN CHANNEL; **NO PRICE PUBLISHED**

20–29 Nov — ★ **Kalaa Utsavam 2026, 25th edition**
ESPLANADE · **SIX FREE PROGRAMMES**; TICKETED FROM **S$29** · PAATI'S SPICE KITCHEN 21–22 NOV FROM S$40

26–28 Nov — **Attack on Titan Symphony · From Paradis**
ESPLANADE CONCERT HALL, 7.30PM · S$99–189 · **RATED NC16 — UNDER-16S CANNOT ATTEND**

3–6 Dec — **Voices · A Festival of Song**
ESPLANADE · WORKSHOPS **FROM S$15**; SAMA-SAMA FROM S$25 · THE CHEAPEST THING HERE SHE CAN JOIN IN

21–24 Jan — **ART SG 2027, *fifth edition***
MARINA BAY SANDS EXPO · **TICKETS NOT YET ON SALE**; THE FAIR'S OWN PAGE CARRIES A PLACEHOLDER

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

23–25 Oct — ★ **Bespoked Osaka 2026**
GLION MUSEUM, MINATO WARD · **70+ MAKERS**, FIRST ASIAN EDITION · **ADVANCE TICKETS CLOSE THU 22 OCT**; DOOR COSTS MORE (P15)

1–25 Nov — **Kichirei Kaomise Ōkabuki**
KABUKIZA, GINZA · DARK 9 AND 17 · **ON SALE NOW**; SINGLE-ACT GALLERY SEATS ARE THE CHILD-VIABLE WAY IN

29 NOV — **Japan Cup (G1)**
TOKYO RACECOURSE, FUCHŪ · **RESERVED-SEAT PRICES NOT PUBLISHED** ON THE ASSOCIATION'S OWN PAGE

14 NOV — **Kabukiza December tickets go on sale**
SHOCHIKU'S OWN STATED ON-SALE DATE FOR THE 2–25 DEC PROGRAMME

8 Jan–4 Apr — ★ **Neverending Journeys · Final Fantasy at 40**
TOKYO NATIONAL MUSEUM, HYŌKEIKAN, UENO · **SOLD BY COMPULSORY TIME SLOT**; PRICES NOT PRIMARY-CONFIRMED

4–11 Feb — **Sapporo Snow Festival 2027**
ODORI, TSUDOME, SUSUKINO · **ADMISSION DETAIL NOT YET PUBLISHED**; THE CONSTRAINT IS HOTELS, NOT TICKETS

27–28 Mar — **AnimeJapan 2027 — now in Osaka**
INTEX OSAKA, **NOT TOKYO BIG SIGHT** · A VENUE MOVE THAT CHANGES THE WHOLE TRIP

PLANNING NOTES · AND WHAT THIS DESK DROPPED

Age gates are this month's trap, not sell-outs. The **Attack on Titan Symphony is NC16** and a twelve-year-old cannot go, while the **Jujutsu Kaisen** concert three weeks earlier admits **from age six** — which is exactly the pair most likely to be mis-bought. If the household wants one anime-orchestral night, book 31 October. **Three things need action inside a fortnight**, in order: Bespoked's advance tickets close **Thursday**; **Tokyo Marathon volunteer entry runs 4–15 November** and overseas volunteers must register their membership first, so start now, not on the 4th — the runner ballot closed in September; and **Kabukiza's December seats go on sale 14 November**. **Dropped for want of a primary source:** Attack on Titan: The Musical, whose venue, presenter and ticketer all refused this desk although its early-bird deadline falls inside the fortnight; **Christmas Wonderland**, for a third issue, no 2026 dates existing at source; the **Standard Chartered marathon**, whose site still carries only 2025; **teamLab Borderless**; **My Chemical Romance** and **Guns N' Roses**, both re-tested this week and still aggregator-only; the **Melbourne Cup**; and **Chingay 2027**, whose official site is still on 2026. **Post Malone remains barred.**[1]

SOURCES 1 Every event above was confirmed on a primary page — the show's, the venue's, the festival's, the organiser's or the official ticketer's own site — and read there on 19 and 20 October 2026: **Bespoked's own Osaka page** for the dates, the venue, the maker count, the advance-ticket deadline and the statement that door tickets cost more; Esplanade's own pages for Popaholic, Jujutsu Kaisen, Kalaa Utsavam, the Attack on Titan Symphony and Voices, including every price, every free-programme count and both age ratings; the official ticketer's own channel for the Monteiro date; ART SG's own visit page for the dates and the ticket placeholder; **Shochiku's own kabuki portal** for both programmes, their dark days and the 14 November on-sale date; the racing authority's own English site for the Japan Cup; the Tokyo National Museum's own site for the Final Fantasy dates; the snow festival's own Japanese site for its dates and its statement that details will follow; and **AnimeJapan's own site for the move to Osaka. Aggregator listings were treated as leads only. Everything that could not be confirmed on a primary source was dropped rather than printed, and is named above. Ticketmaster Singapore, the Marina Bay Sands and Base Entertainment sites, the sumo association's ticket pages and the Melbourne venue all refused this desk.**

THE TABLE · FOUR NEW ROOMS

Rawr Cafe opened on Jalan Besar three days ago from the Wunderfolks group

Of this month's four, one is three days old, two are returning to this page after two years, and Matsuya has not opened at all.

Rawr Cafe opened at **134 Jalan Besar** on **17 October**, a tiger-themed room from **Wunderfolks**, the group behind two established cafés — the reason to take it seriously rather than file it as a photo opportunity. The menu translates local flavours into Western brunch: a **nasi lemak chicken burger at S$18**, laksa cream halibut **S$24**, and a kaya-foam **Singaporean Breakfast Latte at S$8**. Daily 9.30 to 9, not halal-certified, no bookings published.[1]

The single tasting is candid enough to quote against the room. The chilli crab pasta tasted **"more like regular red pasta sauce than chilli crab"**, and the prawn paste chicken resembled ordinary har cheong gai with chicken **"slightly pinker than expected"** — a flag, not a quibble. The verdict — **"definitely worth a visit if you love cutesy cafes"** — recommends the room more than the kitchen, and is reported that way. **Three days old: there is no public verdict and this desk will not imply one.**[1]

Miura returns to this page for the first time since **No. 111**, with the thing it lacked then: agreement. It is a Japanese tea and wagashi stand at the back of a shophouse at **316 Joo Chiat Road**, largely takeaway. Matcha whisked to order from **S$7.50**, daifuku from **S$7**. **Three local outlets now converge**: rich, umami-forward matcha with a bitter finish, and a daifuku built on a whole Japanese strawberry. The honest limit is that nobody claims more for it than it claims for itself.[2]

LingZhi Greens is the heritage story, and it has a genuine new peg since **No. 114**. The vegetarian house, trading since **1991**, has rebranded at **Palais Renaissance** under executive chef **Michael Huang** and **dropped processed mock meats** — building instead on whole ingredients, with fungi doing the work. For a thirty-five-year-old institution to walk away from the mock-meat formula it helped popularise here is a reposition, not a refresh. Lotus-root ribs **S$22**, mapo tofu with peach gum **S$24**, wasabi-mayo monkey-head mushroom **S$28**. **Sources disagree on the reopening date, and five platform reviews are not a consensus.**[3]

The fourth has not opened. **Matsuya**, one of Japan's big three beef-bowl chains at roughly **1,200 locations** at home, takes its first Singapore unit at **Suntec City, #B1-125**, in **November**. In Japan a beef bowl is **¥480** and a full meal runs **¥400 to ¥1,000**. **No Singapore pricing is published and no hours are set.** The useful question for the follow-up: if that three-to-eight-dollar band survives the journey, it reprices the category.[4]

THE CHATTER · THE ROUNDUPS KEEP CIRCULATING THE SAME ROOMS

Two of October's big local roundups were largely unusable here: between them they name more than thirty venues this book has already run to the end of its own rotation rule. That churn is itself a signal. Two more were cut for having run on this page inside the seven-issue window this book enforces on itself.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · FOUR ROOMS, THREE TASTINGS, NO DINERS

Count the evidence honestly. **Every verdict on this page comes from a named outlet; not one comes from a diner.** Burpple returned 403 to every request, Instagram is unreadable, and **Reddit has refused this desk for a sixth consecutive issue**, so the local food subreddits are out of evidence entirely. That is not a gap in the searching — it is the honest state of the information, and a column that let launch copy stand in for a verdict would read exactly like this page while telling the reader nothing.[5]

SOURCES *1 A Singapore food site's review of 19 October 2026, read at source, for the address, the parentage, every price, the hours and all four quoted judgements.* ***That article gives the opening date as 2027, which against its own publication date is plainly a typo for 17 October 2026; the year is not reprinted.*** *2 Three Singapore outlets of around September 2026 — a food site, a listings magazine and a review site — all read at source, for the location, the parentage, the format, every price and the convergence of their verdicts.* ***Its first run on this page was No. 111, twenty-seven issues ago, so this is a legal second and final run under the table ledger.*** *3 A Singapore lifestyle title's review of 12 October 2026 and a second Singapore site's roundup, both read at source, for the rebrand, the founding year, the chef, the mock-meat decision, every dish and price and the appetiser floor.* ***A booking platform shows five reviews and dates the reopening to August, earlier than the September positioning in both write-ups; the conflict is printed rather than resolved, and five platform reviews are not treated as a verdict. Its first run was No. 114, twenty-four issues ago.*** *4 A Singapore food site of 19 October 2026, read at source, for the unit, the address, the month, the chain's scale, every yen price and the kiosk ordering.* ***Single-sourced; the writer states plainly that little is known about the Singapore outlet, and no Japanese enthusiasm is rendered here as a Singapore review.*** *5 The two October roundups named above, read at source, and* ***this book's own table ledger, against which every candidate was checked — two were dropped for having run inside the seven-issue window. Burpple returned 403 and Reddit refused this desk for a sixth issue; no diner sentiment appears here and none was invented.***

THE UNDERCURRENT · LAN WEI LOU

Pre-sale cancellations in Taiwan reached 3,457 in seven months, up 81 per cent

Pre-sale transactions fell 73 per cent in 2025 and Taiwan's unsold inventory hit a record 332,000 units — while the central bank spent September loosening the clamp.

The word is a loan, and that is the point. ***爲尾樓*** *— làn wěi lóu, "rotten-tail building" — is what mainland China calls a tower abandoned halfway up, and Taiwanese newspapers spent 2022 explaining why the island was immune. In* **July 2022**, *as 284 Chinese developments issued mortgage-strike notices, a state-bank executive told the Taiwanese press there was nothing to fear because land prices were high:* ***"you need only hand it to another developer to take over."*** *Two months later a weekly ran a cheerful headline about Taipei's own stalled towers finding a way out of the dead end. The word has since stopped describing somebody else.*[1]

Begin with the product, because it is stranger than a mortgage. In Taiwan a household buys a flat that does not exist. It signs a ***預售屋*** *contract — a pre-sold house — pays a signing instalment, then pays in stages against construction progress for two or three years, and takes out a mortgage only at handover.* ***That is not a deposit. It is construction finance, supplied by the buyer.*** *The system was invented in the* ***early 1960s****, when banks had stopped lending to builders, by a developer who realised a household would pay as it was built. A scholar of the system calls it what it is: a way of selling* ***"the dream of the home's future appreciation"****.*[2]

> ***Nobody has defaulted on a mortgage, because nobody has reached the mortgage yet. The failure happens upstream, where there is no instrument to measure it.***

Now the numbers, read off the central bank's own tables. Pre-sale contracts registered ran **127,942 in 2024**; **41,734** *in the first seven months of 2025;* **20,594** *in the same months of 2026. Transactions fell* **73 per cent** *in the first ten months of 2025 against a year earlier. In the second quarter of 2026 the thirty-day sales rate across the seven major cities averaged* **5.95 per cent**, *and* **more than eighty per cent of pre-sale projects sold less than a tenth of their units in a month**. *Unsold inventory reached a record* **332,000**. *Quarterly transactions halved against the post-2020 average.*[3]

And the cancellations. By year of cancellation: **four in 2022**, **819 in 2023**, **2,133 in 2024**, **3,686 in 2025** *— and* **3,457 in the first seven months of 2026 alone**, *up* **81 per cent** *on the same months a year before. The cumulative total since July 2021 is* **9,751**. *These are households walking away from flats they have been paying for, forfeiting what they have paid, before a single mortgage has been written.*[3]

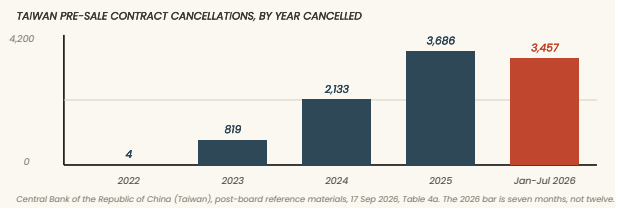
332,000

UNSOLD HOUSING UNITS IN TAIWAN, A RECORD, AND 36.6% ABOVE THE 2021 LEVEL[3]

SOURCES *1 A Taiwanese English-language outlet of 17 July 2022, read at source, for the state-bank executive's quoted remark and the Chinese mortgage-strike context; a Taiwanese weekly of 15 September 2022 for the Taipei headline and the five named stalled projects.* ***The etymology and the mainland usage are long-established and are stated as background, not as a finding.*** *2* ***Lin Wang-ken, "The Evolution and Transformation of Our Country's Pre-sale System", in the Taiwan Real Estate Almanac 2022, published by National Chengchi University's real-estate research centre — downloaded as a PDF and text-extracted****, for the 1960s origin, the 1969 lending withdrawal, the named originator and the quoted characterisation of what the system sells. 3* ***The Central Bank of the Republic of China (Taiwan), post-board-meeting reference materials of 17 September 2026, downloaded as a PDF and text-extracted****, for the registered-contract series, every cancellation figure, the annual and seven-month totals and the cumulative count, all from its Tables 4a and 4b, which cite the interior ministry's own transaction database. The 73 per cent fall is an estate agency's research as carried by a Taiwanese financial daily, read at source; the thirty-day sales rates and the eighty-per-cent figure are the Cathay real-estate index, compiled with a university team, as carried by a Taiwanese business daily, read at source; the inventory record is a property-data firm's, in the same reporting.*

What makes this a story rather than a downturn is the safety net, which was built, dismantled and never replaced. Since **1 May 2011** *every pre-sale contract must carry one of five* ***履約擔保*** *mechanisms — performance securities. Read what each actually promises and the architecture collapses. A price trust returns only the residue and guarantees no completion. A development trust, the same. A price-refund guarantee returns everything paid but guarantees no completion. A peer joint guarantee and a trade-association guarantee promise completion but return nothing. The yearbook's own verdict: apart from the refund guarantee,* ***the other four guarantee neither completion nor the return of money.***[1]

The mechanism is supposed to be negotiated between buyer and seller. In practice, the same source records, ***the developer picks and the consumer has no say*** *— and the one door with real teeth, the refund guarantee, costs roughly* ***one per cent of the price per year*** *and is therefore rarely chosen. The most-used door is the weakest: one developer guaranteeing another, under qualification rules covering only the guarantor's age, capital and turnover. The documented result is affiliated companies guaranteeing each other, loss-making companies issuing guarantees, and guarantors whose representatives are spouses or relatives of the developer's.*[1]



Four in 2022; 3,457 in seven months of 2026. **Meridian original, plotted from the central bank's own Table 4a.** The last bar covers seven months, not twelve.[2]

Even the word "trust" does less than it sounds. To the trustee bank the buyer's instalments and the developer's own equity are both simply the developer's money. Some trustees hold back about fifteen per cent to the end; others pay construction costs first, on the developer's instruction. When the developer then fails there is no residue, and the beneficiary right — transferable to the buyer — has become what Taiwanese buyers call ***壁紙****, wallpaper. The queue is worse than that. A lawyer acting in a Chiayi collapse explained that the completed structure carries a* **statutory mortgage** *ranking ahead of the consumer, so buyers come out* ***"well down the queue, as an ordinary debt".***[3]

There is a precise historical rhyme, and it is Taiwan's own. In **1986** *the interior ministry created a licensed construction-management industry* ***explicitly modelled on the American escrow mechanism****: banks had to hold at least* **30 per cent** *of each firm's paid-in capital, one bank to one company, minimum capital* **NT$50 million***. Twenty-four bank-backed firms resulted. Then in* **2001** *an amendment to the administrative-procedure law required such regulations to acquire explicit statutory authority within two years. The 1986 rule never did, and in* **December 2003 it was repealed***. The industry fell under the ordinary companies act; a replacement bill was blocked and never passed; the banks withdrew.* ***Taiwan built an escrow trustee in 1986 and took it apart in 2003, and nobody replaced it.*** *The mechanism that failed in 2026 had been hollow for twenty-three years.*[4]

> ***The buyers who lost money in Chiayi were protected by a regime whose enforcement arm had been abolished before their flats were drawn.***

SOURCES 1 ***The Taiwan Real Estate Almanac 2022 chapter cited at p21, downloaded and text-extracted****, for the 2011 commencement, the five mechanisms, its Table 5-1-1 setting out what each returns and guarantees, the quoted verdict on the four, the developer's unilateral choice, the cost of the refund guarantee and every documented abuse of the peer-guarantee qualification rules. 2 The central bank's own Table 4a, as at p21 note 3.* ***The chart is this desk's, plotted from those published figures; the final bar is seven months and is labelled as such.*** *3 The same yearbook chapter for the trustee's treatment of buyer instalments, the hold-back practice and the wallpaper term;* ***Taiwan's public broadcaster, 30 May 2025, read at source****, for the Chiayi case and the lawyer's quoted explanation of the statutory mortgage and the creditor queue. 4 The same yearbook chapter, for the 1986 regulation and its promulgation date, the bank shareholding requirement, the capital minimum, the number of firms created, the explicit escrow model, the 2001 amendment, the 2003 repeal, the blocked replacement bill and the banks' withdrawal.* ***The twenty-three-year arithmetic is this desk's.***

The strongest objection to this essay is the central bank's, and it is official, specific and in print. In its **June 2026** reference materials the bank devotes a numbered question to the **32 "developer collapse" disputes recorded in Tainan in the fourth quarter of 2025** — and names the newspaper it is rebutting. Its answer: although classified as collapses, the 32 were **"in substance transaction disputes between buyers and one single project"**. All thirty-two arose from one development, whose original developer, short of working capital, sold a completed-but-not-handed-over project to another — and **"the original developer did not collapse"**. It adds that the first quarter of 2026 contained no such disputes at all.[1]

That is a fair hit on the headline and it does not touch the argument. The cancellations are the bank's own number, from its own table, and they went up **81 per cent**. The inventory record is not disputed by anyone. And the bank's own actions read against its own reassurance: on **18 September 2026** it raised the loan-to-value ceiling on a second home from **60 to 70 per cent** and scrapped the eighteen-month construction-start undertaking on land loans — having already moved that ceiling from 50 to 60 in March. Its governor said policy could not be ***硬邦邦***, rigid, that Taiwan would **"walk its own path"**, and that he hoped for a soft landing. He acknowledged that some board members dissented.[2]

Meanwhile the state quietly plumbed in something new. On **7 October 2026** a state-shareholding asset manager and a cooperative bank signed a ***續建資金承諾*** — a continuation-construction funding commitment — capped at **30 per cent of construction cost** and available **when the developer applies for construction finance** rather than, as before, only after a site has stood halted for three months. Its chairman was explicit about why: the existing mechanism **"often cannot work, precisely because of a shortage of funds"**, and there is **"no need to wait until a site has been halted for three months"**. Governments do not build emergency plumbing for problems they believe are press artefacts.[3]

A central bank that is loosening and a state fund that is pre-positioning rescue finance are not two readings of the same market. They are one institution hedging against the other's forecast.

Here is the argument. Taiwan built a housing system in which **ordinary households are the construction lenders of last resort** — unsecured, involuntary, and ranking behind the statutory mortgage. For sixty years that was invisible, because prices rose and every project completed. What has changed is not the risk but the liquidity: **starts of about 380,000 units in 2023–2025 must be completed and handed over in 2026–2028**, and the developer's cash now has to arrive as the final instalment from buyers who, as the estate agents' chairman puts it, **"don't refuse to take possession; they simply can't raise the money."** His sharper line is the one to carry: **"a market without liquidity is itself the greatest risk."**[4]

Which is why the revealed preference matters more than any forecast. Asked what they now want, **47 per cent** of one agency's respondents chose a completed home under five years old and **38 per cent** an older resale — a flight to what can be seen and touched. Asked whether the government's contract reform would make them likelier to buy pre-sale, **7.7 per cent** said clearly yes. Buyers have not panicked. They have quietly stopped lending. **The question Taiwan has not answered is who finances construction when the households decline — and it is the question every pre-sale market in Asia will eventually be asked.**[5]

7.7%

TAIWANESE BUYERS WHO SAID THE CONTRACT REFORM WOULD CLEARLY MAKE THEM LIKELIER TO BUY PRE-SALE[5]

*SOURCES 1 **The Central Bank of the Republic of China (Taiwan), first-half 2026 reference materials, downloaded as a PDF and text-extracted**, for the numbered question, the footnote naming the newspaper and its 16 March 2026 article, both quoted rebuttals, the first-quarter figure and the share of funding-related disputes. 2 The same bank's own decree notice and a Taiwanese business daily of 17 September 2026, both read at source, for the loan-to-value change, its effective date, the scrapping of the construction-start undertaking and the governor's quoted remarks and acknowledgement of dissent; the March move is confirmed in the bank's own materials. 3 A Taiwanese financial daily of 8 October 2026 and a market-data reprint of 7 October, both read at source, for the signing, the two signatories, the thirty-per-cent cap, the timing change against the legacy mechanism and both quoted statements from the asset manager's chairman. 4 An estate agency's published trend report of 25 December 2025 for the 2023–2025 starts and the 2026–2028 handover wave; a Taiwanese financial weekly of 2 February 2026, read at source, for both quoted lines from the chairman of the estate agents' association. 5 An agency member survey published 31 March 2026, read at source, for both preference percentages; a second agency's quarterly survey, read at source, for the 7.7 per cent figure, **which is single-sourced. Searches for discussion of this subject on Taiwan's two main social boards returned only property-press articles; no forum texture is reported and none was invented. No feature on Taiwan's pre-sale market, unfinished buildings or escrow reform was found at any of ten major Western outlets.***

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

The pass-through

One shock, and the doors it came out of. American energy prices rose ***20.4 per cent*** *in the year to September, which is most of a 3.7 per cent headline and the reason the Federal Reserve is still raising into a slowing economy (p14). On Monday global equities and global bonds fell together while every Treasury yield rose — diversification failing for the textbook reason, because this is a supply shock and not a growth scare. Gold fell during a shooting war in the world's main oil chokepoint, because at a 5.15 per cent ten-year the carrying cost beats the haven bid.*

The same bill arrives elsewhere as politics. In France it came out as ***550,000*** *marchers,* ***2,400*** *arrests and a curfew on Place de la République, with the president in Kuwait on Monday asking for diesel (p3). In Singapore it came out as a wage guideline —* ***6 to 8 per cent*** *for workers under S$2,800, recommended, not required, in a year when barely a quarter of employers met the last one (p5). Two countries, one pressure, two instruments: one of them advisory, and one of them 60,000 police.*

And where the instrument fails, the number goes with it. The body that counts attacks in the Gulf now says it is ***"struggling to accurately report true number of attacks"*** *(p4). Taiwan built an escrow trustee in 1986, repealed it in 2003, and found out in 2026 what households had been underwriting for twenty-three years (p21). Against all of it, one thing kept its appointment: at twenty to four this morning a Japanese rocket left Tanegashima, and in 2031 it will put ten grams of a Martian moon down in Australia.*

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

MERIDIAN · No. 138 · 20 October 2026

SOURCES *A note on method.* This edition's load-bearing figures were read where they are published: the Bureau of Labor Statistics' own September price release and the US Treasury's own daily par yield curve, read row by row; the Élysée's own text of the president's address; the White House's own text of the Graham Act waiver, which corrects two details printed in No. 137; the Monetary Authority of Singapore's own statement; the Ministry of Manpower's own releases and Singapore's own air-quality interface, read directly at two endpoints; EnterpriseSG's own trade release, downloaded as a PDF and text-extracted, which clears a figure held since No. 136; Xinhua for China's export announcements; a Japanese broadcaster and a Japanese business daily for this morning's launch; the Journal of the Acoustical Society of America; Box Office Mojo, Metacritic and Rotten Tomatoes; Hugging Face and GitHub; and the Central Bank of the Republic of China (Taiwan)'s own board materials and a National Chengchi University yearbook chapter, both downloaded and text-extracted. Where a source refused this desk — Reddit for a sixth consecutive issue, and this week also Reuters, the FT, the BBC, the Guardian, the Economist, both Singapore broadsheets, CNA, Burpple, the Acoustic Guitar Forum, UMGF, Reverb, and every framebuilding forum tried — the page says so and prints what could be read instead. Two corrections run on p4, and a clarification on p7. Nothing here was invented.